

**J.K. MITRA**

Dean, Faculty of Management Studies

There are no conscious preferences on the part of top B-schools to shortlist candidates from engineering backgrounds. All institutes want to have more diversity in their classes. Because of this, they actively try to spot bright candidates from non-engineering fields. The fact that more and more engineering students are making it to the prestigious B-schools can be justified on the grounds that their study habits and work ethics are much in sync with the requirements of a B-school campus. Because of this they do not find any difficulty in adjusting in corporate environment. Moreover, an engineer is at least a year older to a three-year degree course holder, which makes him chronologically more mature. Besides, most engineers also master the art of cracking competitive exams, as entry to any top-level engineering college is as difficult as getting through a good B-school. All these elements give engineering candidates an upper hand over others, who may be equally bright but not exposed to the corporate world.



A PRABHAKAR RAO

work experience and a statement of purpose when selecting a candidate. Most Indian B-schools, however, do not follow a similar pattern.

Some schools claim that such a procedure would be hard to follow in India, given the large applicant pool. "In India we have to follow a strict, inflexible pattern and keep the system as transparent as possible in order to avoid controversies," explains Mukherji. But the Indian School of Business (ISB), the only Indian institute to break into the list of top 20 colleges in the world, seems to have successfully followed the Western formula. ISB considers GMAT scores for shortlisting candidates and a two-year work experience is mandatory. Its class profile with 56 per cent engineers, although not the healthiest, is still way better than the scenario in the other top B-schools.

Even the lopsided male-female ratio is linked with the the flawed testing procedures. "Fewer women are motivated to develop a quantitative edge during their academic life. Parents do not feel such streams lead to a safe desk-oriented job," says Deven Dhanak, adjunct faculty at Symbiosis Institute of Management Studies (SIMS), Pune. Owing to its different entrance examination, MICA seems to have more women than men in its management programmes.

Even though the gender imbalance is rather pronounced in India

SPOT A GIRL: Skewed gender ratio plagues all top B-schools

(IIM-A has 5.7 per cent women in its 2009 batch), this is a trend plaguing B-schools in most countries. Social pressure on women to raise a family during the prime of their working careers is one of the factors. "We require candidates with work experience. This pushes the average age of our class to 28. At this age, few women can leave aside social responsibilities for academics," explains Bhuvana Ramalingam, ISB's senior director, communications. ISB Dean M.R. Rao further elaborates on this, "In a survey, we discovered that women do not have enough role models in the business world and this could be one of the reasons." There is also an industry bias, where most recruiters from fields such as investment banking or project management seem to prefer men. There are only a handful of areas such as human resource, communication management in which employers give preference to women candidates.

Diversity is a key ingredient in any good B-school. Multiplicity of voices always provides a new insight, which is crucial in understanding the world of business. It is high time the Indian B-schools woke up to this fact and revamped their selection procedures if they have to produce global managers for the future. ■